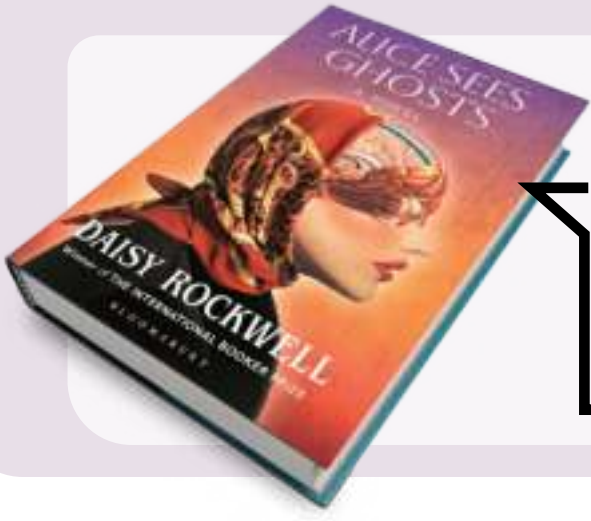
DOWN THE RABBIT HOLE

Daisy Rockwell displays her **mastery of language and character** *in* Alice Sees Ghosts

When we are introduced to the protagonist of Daisy Rockwell's novel *Alice Sees Ghosts*, she is worried that she sounds too formal and contrived in her speech, as though she were "speaking written language". Alice has just recovered from an extended bout of aphasia (a language disorder that affects one's ability to speak) with the help of kindly psychiatrist Ronit, who ends their professional relationship and becomes engaged to her soon afterwards. A surprise visit from the ghost of her grandfather prompts Alice to go to India in search of her family's connection to the land—why did her grandfather take secretive annual trips to Rishikesh, much to her grandmother Nanette's irritation? Ronit, torn between his concern for Alice's well-being and his professional curiosity about her visions, tags along. Once the India-set portions of the novel begin, the lines between fact and fiction, history and hearsay, reality and hallucination, start blurring very quickly.



ALICE SEES GHOSTS
By Daisy Rockwell
BLOOMSBURY INDIA
₹699; 272 pages

As propulsive as that mystery proves to be, the principal pleasures of *Alice Sees Ghosts* lie in Rockwell's deployment of language and her instinctual understanding of character development. We chuckle when Rockwell, introducing us to Ronit, tells us that Alice "(...) routinely discounted his medical opinions now that he shared her bed". We marvel at the economy with which Rockwell establishes the dysfunctional dynamics between Alice, her alcoholic, acerbic mother Clare and Clare's own mother Nanette. ("She had always considered Nanette an emotional refuge, but she wondered if her ability to freeze opposition with a chilly stare of disapproval could have helped to shape the person her mother had become.") By the end of the novel, we acknowledge that what we call a 'ghost' is inextricably linked with the thousand and one emotions we repress every day. And in this context, closure is hard to achieve. We never really say 'goodbye' to our ghosts, what we say instead is "until we meet again". ■

—Aditya Mani Jha

gether cutting-edge work happening in the Indian comics space. This edition has been put together by comics practitioners Debkumar Mitra, Pinaki De and Argha Manna. "The name Longform comes from one of Sacco's essays," says Mitra. "He was addressing the shrinking space for long graphic stories. Our effort is to show the works of talented artists who don't get much opportunities early in their career. We also have an ideology that is rooted in resistance."

WE SEE THEMES LIKE **CLIMATE CHANGE, GRIEF, PATRIARCHY AND COMMUNAL DISHARMONY** ACROSS THE COLLECTION

Across 300 pages, we see themes like climate change, pollution, grief, death, patriarchy, capitalism and communal disharmony provoked by the government. And, of course, cats. "The story is the most important driving force," says De. "It is okay even if the artwork isn't that great, but there has to be an element of subversion in the narrative." The all-male editors have taken efforts to ensure the collection is egalitarian. More than half the contributors are not cisgendered men, De points out. Additionally, he says, "we have ensured only 25 per cent of the entries are by established writers." What next? "We are contemplating a new anthology with the theme... India," Mitra says. ■

—Devarsi Ghosh